

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Micah 1:1

Micah is presumably a short form of Micaiah, which means “Who is like the Lord?” • Moresheth was a fortress city located a short distance southeast of Gath in the low-lying hills of southwestern Judah. • Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah (see Micah Book Introduction, “Setting”): The reigns of these three kings covered about 65 years total (about 750–686 BC). • God’s message came to Micah in visions. • Samaria and Jerusalem were the capitals of northern Israel and Judah. Sometimes these city names refer to their entire countries.

Micah 1:2

Attention! translates the same word that introduces the *Shema* (“Listen!”) in [Deut 6:4](#). • The holy Temple is the Lord’s heavenly abode, not the corrupt Temple in Jerusalem ([Mic 1:2-3](#)).

Micah 1:2-7

This oracle concerns Samaria prior to 722 BC, when Samaria was destroyed and its people were deported. The Sovereign Lord was coming to judge his people.

Micah 1:2-2.13

This message of judgment introduces some of the major concerns of Micah’s prophecies and asserts God’s determination to judge his people and put them into exile ([1:16](#); [2:4-5](#)), but it concludes with the Lord’s assurance that he will rescue a remnant from exile ([2:12-13](#)).

Micah 1:3

Tramples the heights implies a theophany, an appearance of the God who is behind the historical convulsions about to afflict Samaria (cp. [Deut 33:29](#); [Ps 108:13](#); [Amos 4:13](#)). God is sovereign over nations and nature. The Canaanite god Baal was also thought to be active in this manner—

descriptions of God like this one emphasize that the Lord, not Baal, is truly sovereign.

Micah 1:4

The strong and apparently immovable mountains will melt at the Lord’s presence (see [Ps 97:5](#)). Nothing can stand against him.

Micah 1:5

Rebellion is parallel to sins; these two key words describe Israel’s failure in the Old Testament. • Who? . . . Where? The capital cities of God’s people should have been holy places, but they were sources of corruption instead. Samaria, capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, was built by Omri (885–874 BC) as a political, military, and economic crossroads of the ancient Near East ([1 Kgs 16:24](#)). Omri was an evil king, and so his city was evil (cp. [Mic 6:16](#), [1 Kgs 16:25](#)). • Jerusalem: The prophet would not allow the people of Judah to be smug about the northern kingdom’s imminent destruction. Judah’s beautiful Temple was no different from a Canaanite center of idolatry (literally *high place*).

Micah 1:6-7

a heap of ruins: The Lord threatened to devastate his treasured cities. Assyria virtually annihilated Samaria in 724–722 BC in a horrendous three-year siege. • Samaria, like most cities, was built on a hill. Here, the stones of her walls crash into the valley below as they are violently dismantled. Ancient armies would systematically shatter city walls down to their foundation stones. • Samaria and Jerusalem were filled with carved images and sacred treasures put there by worshipers or taken as war booty. • Prostitution pictures Israel’s persistent spiritual and physical waywardness. This metaphor was regularly used by the Israelite prophets to express Israel’s abandonment of the Lord, her true husband, in order to obtain the blessings promised by the pagan gods. In addition, the worship of those gods often in fact involved sexual activity. • Elsewhere refers to the exile of Samaria into Assyria and its various provinces and

conquered vassal states (722 BC). The same outcome was forecast for Jerusalem ([3:12](#); [Jer 26:18](#)).

Micah 1:8–16

In response to the Lord's predicted judgment, Micah walked around barefoot and naked to express mourning (cp. [Isa 20:2](#); [Lam 2:10](#); [Ezek 24:17](#)), vividly depicting what would happen to Samaria (Israel) and Jerusalem (Judah). They would be stripped of their wealth, power, and population. • A jackal and an owl make forlorn sounds and live in forsaken wilderness areas ([Isa 34:13](#); [Jer 50:39](#)).

Micah 1:9

into Judah . . . Jerusalem: The corruption now permeated the entire nation, north to south.

Micah 1:10–15

The cities listed were in the lowlands of southwestern Judah's coastal areas. The sequence may represent the Assyrian army's march down the coastal plain and from there into Judah's heartland in 703–701 BC.

Micah 1:11

Exile was the ultimate, most devastating curse ([Deut 4:29](#); [28:37](#), [48](#); [Jer 25:7–11](#)).

Micah 1:12

even to . . . Jerusalem: God's judgment reaches wherever corruption has taken hold (cp. [1:9](#)).

Micah 1:13

Lachish was the second most important city in Judah, after Jerusalem, and was Judah's main center of defense against their enemies. Even today, a massive *tell* over 150 feet (46 meters) high remains. Lachish fell in 701 BC, having been besieged, terrified, starved, and demolished by

Sennacherib's war engines. Sennacherib celebrated its fall as one of his greatest victories and featured the event in monumental carvings on his palace walls.

Micah 1:14

Farewell gifts said good-bye to the doomed people of Moresheth-gath as that city also became Assyrian property.

Micah 1:15

the leaders (literally *the glory*): The leaders of Israel should have been Israel's "glory" by setting examples of moral excellence and wise, caring leadership. Instead, God's shepherds corrupted their nation. • Adullam was destroyed by Assyria in 701 BC.

Micah 1:16

The people of Judah, including Jerusalem, were exiled and deported to distant lands in Babylonia in 605, 597, and 586 BC. Babylon was some 1,000 miles (1,700 kilometers) from Jerusalem. • shave your heads: This act of mourning and despair (see also [Jer 41:5](#)) could also signify purification ([Lev 14:7–10](#); [Num 6:10–11](#)).

Micah 2:1–2

Power had corrupted the wealthy, who should have been ready to help their fellow Israelites (cp. [Gen 4:9](#); [Josh 1:14](#)). • Thinking up evil plans . . . because you have the power to do so indicates a corrupt heart, mind, and character ([Gen 6:5](#)). • When you want: They possessed the property of others in a way that amounted to stealing and broke God's law that forbids coveting ([Exod 20:17](#)). A family's inheritance was a sacred gift from the Lord, intended as a permanent possession ([Lev 25:8–55](#); cp. [1 Kgs 21](#); [Isa 5:8](#)). God looked for righteousness among his people, but instead he found oppression ([1 Kgs 10:9](#); [Isa 5:7](#); [2 Pet 2:13](#)).

Micah 2:3-5

The Lord, the Judge, reads out the sentence. He would pay back his people's evil hearts and actions with evil in kind. The prophet is engaging in wordplay here. The Hebrew word translated "evil" has a wide range of meaning. It can connote moral evil, as in the first instance; it can also connote calamity or disaster as in the second instance. The Lord would bring calamity on them in response to their wickedness.

Micah 2:4

The power brokers would be ruined financially as their enemies confiscated their property. The land that they had seized unjustly from fellow Israelites would be violently taken from them ([2:5](#)).

Micah 2:6

There was a pathetic attempt to stifle the words of a true prophet. • the people respond: They thought that exile and other such disasters could not happen to them, but they were wrong.

Micah 2:7-10

The maltreatment of their fellow Israelites was tantamount to an attack against the Lord and his prophet. The fault lay with the people, not with Micah's inspired and righteous message.

Micah 2:11

These evil people loved to hear deceptions from their favorite good-time prophets (cp. [Jer 28:8-9](#)). False prophets proclaimed assurance that Israel and Judah could escape from judgment. When judgment came, they had no comfort to give.

Micah 2:12-13

God showed his love and care for his rebellious people by giving them a promise of hope even as he spoke of exile and despair. Israel would be scattered, but they would be brought back (cp. [Deut 4:26-29](#); [30:1-6](#)).

Micah 2:13

The Lord did lead Israel out of exile, foreshadowing the even greater freedom from slavery that the Messiah, Jesus Christ, would later bring.

Micah 3:1

The leaders, who were supposed to know true judgment and justice ([6:8](#); [Deut 10:12-13](#)), were morally responsible for Israel's guilt.

Micah 3:1-4

Micah relentlessly indicted the leaders of Israel because they were responsible for the peoples' well-being. The horrors here depict the terrors of a people under siege (cp. [Deut 28:53](#); [2 Kgs 6:29](#)).

Micah 3:1-5.15

This message indicts the evil leaders who were destroying God's people and contrasts them with a glorious vision of God's kingdom and the reign of a righteous king. After suffering judgment and exile, a purified people of Israel would return and experience God's blessings.

Micah 3:2-3

The leaders, like wild animals, destroyed their own people.

Micah 3:4

Then: Even after oppressing the Lord's people, the leaders would selfishly beg for help from the Lord.

Micah 3:5

The false prophets were among the spiritual leaders of Israel, so they fell under Micah's accusations. Prophets were supposed to call Israel to the true way, not to send them astray (see [Deut 13, 18](#)). These prophets used their gifts to benefit themselves.

Micah 3:6-7

Micah announced God's judgment on the false prophets. Without God's special communications, these seers and fortune-tellers were like the pagan court prophets of such nations as Babylon, Mari, and especially Assyria, who were expected to toe the party line but who had no real revelation from the Lord (cp. [1 Sam 28:6](#); [Amos 8:11-12](#)).

Micah 3:8

There was a strong contrast between the true prophet and the false prophets ([3:5-7](#)). Truth, justice, and power come from God's Spirit, who gave Micah the moral and ethical strength to declare his true message about the sin and rebellion of his people.

Micah 3:9-12

The leaders of Israel were building Jerusalem on a foundation of murder and corruption. Because of this, the city would be dismantled; it would be reduced to wilderness and ruins ([3:12](#)).

Micah 3:11

the Lord is here among us: This expression indicates the Lord's approval (see [Exod 3:12](#), [14:25:8](#); [Mic 2:5](#); [Zech 2:11](#)) and his dwelling among his people. The false prophets wrongly claimed God's presence.

Micah 3:12

Mount Zion, where the Lord once lived, would become a thicket, an uninhabitable wilderness. Utter destruction awaited the fallen Jerusalem. Jeremiah later quoted this passage ([Jer 26:18](#)). • Just as a field needs to be cleared to prepare it for cultivation, Jerusalem had to be reduced to ruins in judgment.

Micah 4:1-2

In the last days: God promised to act in history to establish his kingdom. • The mountain of the Lord's house was Mount Zion in Jerusalem, where Solomon's Temple was built (see [2 Sam 24:18-25](#)). It recalls Mount Sinai, the mountain of God ([Exod 3:1](#); [Num 10:33](#)), where God appeared. The mountain of the Lord has significance as the place where God makes his identity known and his fellowship available. • teach us his ways . . . his paths: The wisdom of God's laws and the knowledge of his ways will give the nations life ([Deut 4:6](#); [32:47](#)).

Micah 4:1-5

Micah's prophecy moves from utter despair to an eruption of hope as he expresses the future exaltation of Mount Zion in Jerusalem. God's plan to bless all nations ([Gen 12:3](#)) through Abraham's descendants will be realized when the nations and the Lord's people stream to the Lord's house . . . to worship. There (1) they will learn to follow God's law and teachings; (2) the law and teachings will flow out among the nations as they are carried forth from God's house; (3) peace and well-being will grow among the nations as they turn their energies to peaceful purposes and abandon war; and (4) the people will live without fear, having security, prosperity, and blessing ([Mic 4:4](#)). The idols of the nations fail them, but Israel's faithful God accomplishes all this; the prosperity he brings lasts for endless ages ([4:5](#)).

Micah 4:3

The *shalom* ("well-being, peace") of the Lord will cover the earth, and instruments of destruction will be used for peaceful pursuits. From its earliest records, ancient history is an account of war, of one people's subjugation of other peoples and nations. Warfare and violence reached a frenzied peak in the Assyrian and Babylonian kingdoms. • swords into plowshares: Implements of war will become tools for production. Alternatively, some scholars believe that this phrase means reducing "swords into metal shards," which would render them useless.

Micah 4:4

Everyone will be free of enemies as in Solomon's time ([1 Kgs 4:25](#); cp. [Isa 36:16](#); [Zech 3:10](#)). • The prophets frequently described God as the Lord of Heaven's Armies. This military title expresses his control of the universe and his unlimited power. The warrior kings of the ancient Near East were no match for the Lord.

Micah 4:6-7

Usually the remnants of destroyed cities in the ancient Near East were lost or assimilated. When Israel's remnant was rescued, it would be the foundation of the Lord's new people ([Deut 4:26-31](#); [30:1-5](#); [2 Kgs 19:31](#); [Isa 10:21](#); [Jer 29:10-14](#); see [Ezra 9:8](#); [Neh 1:2](#)).

Micah 4:8

As for you, Jerusalem, the citadel of God's people: Jerusalem was a fortified royal capital city with a watchtower for the defense and security of its people. • The kingship will be restored: Cp. [Amos 9:11-15](#); see [2 Sam 7:11-16](#).

Micah 4:9

Israel's king and wise people were supposed to provide leadership and embody the Lord's instructions and covenant in their lives ([Deut 17:18-20](#)). Now, however, the people would be without godly leadership (cp. [Judg 17:6](#); [18:1](#); [21:25](#)).

Micah 4:10

Distant Babylon lay about 1,000 miles (1,700 kilometers) from Jerusalem; it could not be reached by cutting across the barren eastern desert. • The Lord's rescue of his people from sure death in Babylon would surpass his bringing them out of Egypt. They were formed in the womb of suffering and awaited a promising rebirth ([Isa 43:1-5](#); cp. [Ezek 37](#)). • For Micah, Babylon represented the concept of exile. In Micah's time (the late 700s and early 600s BC), there was not even the whisper of a Babylonian empire replacing the Assyrians. But Micah was speaking for God, who knows the future.

Micah 4:11-13

gathered against you: While closely tied to the historical assault of Babylon against Jerusalem in 588-586 BC, this oracle also bears on a future in which the idealized and restored Jerusalem of [4:1-5](#) will be attacked (cp. [Rev 20:7-9](#)).

Micah 4:12

God reveals his plans to his servants ([Dan 2:19-23](#); [Amos 3:7](#)), but the nations don't know—they are not privy to God's great plans or to his behind-the-scenes activity on his people's behalf. The hopes and plans of the nations around Israel were in vain—the Lord's plans for his unique people will prevail, and he will rule the nations ([Gen 12:1-3](#); [15:12-21](#); [Exod 19:4-6](#); [Isa 45:23](#); [66:23](#)). • At the threshing floor, grain was beaten and trampled to separate it from the chaff. So, too, the nations will be crushed ([Mic 4:13](#)).

Micah 4:13

The horns and hooves of bulls and horses represent strength, as do both iron and bronze. Metal shoes may have been used on the feet of animals who trod out the grain. God will strengthen his peoples to defeat their enemies. • stolen riches: Many nations had accumulated wealth by unjust means (war, plunder, oppressive tributes, forced labor, and conscription). The Lord of all the earth owned all of this wealth to begin with ([Exod 19:5](#)). • You will present: The Hebrew term (kharam, "dedicate") refers to military spoils of war that were dedicated, or set aside, as holy to the Lord (see [Lev 27:28-29](#)).

Micah 5:1

Israel's leader was defeated by the Assyrians (cp. [6:9](#)). Striking a person with a rod expressed contempt (cp. [1 Kgs 22:24](#)).

Micah 5:1-15

This section calls Israel to prepare for the vicious onslaught of Israel's enemy, Assyria ([5:5b-6](#)). This siege of terror, death, and destruction will not

annihilate Israel, for God will bring forth a ruler ([5:2-5a](#)) to lead his people back from exile. God's preservation and purification of the remnant ([5:7-14](#)) will complete their restoration as God's victorious people.

Micah 5:2

Ephrathah was the ancient name of Bethlehem ([Gen 35:16](#); [Ruth 4:11](#)), David's birthplace. In the future, an even more significant ruler than David would arise from there ([Matt 2:5-6](#); [John 7:42](#)). The future king's activities would stretch from the distant past (Hebrew qedem; cp. [Deut 33:27](#); [Prov 8:22-23](#); [Isa 37:26](#)) into a still future time, suggesting a divine-human being.

Micah 5:4-5

Following the Exile, Prince Zerubbabel, a descendant of David, was among the returned exiles and became the focus of Israel's hopes (see [Hag 2:20-23](#)). But a greater ruler than Zerubbabel was needed. The leader from Bethlehem would be a source of peace; Isaiah called him the Prince of Peace ([Isa 9:6](#)). Only Jesus fits this description.

Micah 5:5

The Assyrians destroyed northern Israel in 722 BC. Sennacherib shut up King Hezekiah of Jerusalem "like a bird in a cage" (Sennacherib's own words) in 701 BC and devastated over forty-six cities in Judah. The hoped-for deliverer-king did not appear in those days. The Assyrians represent all of Israel's enemies. • seven rulers . . . eight princes: This literary expression indicates that an abundance of leaders will be supplied as needed to lead Israel.

Micah 5:6

the land of Nimrod: Nimrod laid the foundations of the ancient Assyrian and Babylonian civilizations ([Gen 10:8-11](#)).

Micah 5:7

The remnant are those whom God's grace preserved to be the foundation of his new people

([Ezra 9:8-15](#); [Neh 1:2](#)). • Dew and rain are gifts from the Lord; no person can prevent his sending them.

Micah 5:7-15

God's purpose was not to create another nation like all the other nations ([Exod 19:4-6](#); [Num 23:9](#); [Jer 7:23](#)), but to have his own people who would walk in his ways and be holy as he is holy ([Lev 11:45](#)). In that day ([Mic 5:10](#)), God will rule a redeemed and purified people, healed of violence and the ravages of war.

Micah 5:8-9

God's people will have a unique place among the nations of the world ([Gen 12:3](#); [Exod 19:4-6](#)). They will be the head and not the tail ([Deut 28:13](#)), and invincible as a lion (cp. [Esth 6:13](#)) as God gives them hegemony over the nations. • The Lord will judge their foes (see [Mic 5:15](#)) if they continue to rebel against him. The Lord's desire, however, is ultimately to bless the nations, not to curse or destroy them ([Gen 12:3](#); [Jon 4:11](#); [John 3:16](#)).

Micah 5:10-14

The Lord's actions for and against his people purify them. The Lord removed several abominable things imported from the pagan cultures of Mesopotamia and Canaan.

Micah 5:13-14

sacred pillars . . . Asherah poles: Stones were set up as places or objects of worship; they could represent pagan deities. The Asherah poles were green poles or trees that represented the goddess Asherah and her powers of fertility. Both the stones and the trees may have had sexual implications—one male, the other female. Asherah was seen as the mother of gods and El's (or Baal's) consort.

Micah 6:1-2

mountains and hills: All creation is called as a witness (cp. [Josh 24:27](#)); in other ancient Near

Eastern treaties, the gods of the respective countries were called as witnesses.

Micah 6:1–16

The Lord presented, argued, and decided the case against his rebellious people, Israel. This section is formally presented as a legal court case (cp. [Isa 1:2–4](#); [Jer 2:4–9](#); [Hos 4](#)). Using the scenario of the courtroom, the Lord challenged his people to state their case against him, for he had a case against them ([Mic 6:1–5](#))—they had not fulfilled his requirements ([6:6–8](#)), so they were guilty ([6:9–12](#)). The guilty verdict is followed by Israel's sentencing ([6:13–16](#)).

Micah 6:3

tired of me: The Lord asks rhetorically if he has done something to turn Israel away from him. But their contempt for God arose from their own ingratitude ([6:4–5](#)).

Micah 6:4–5

The Lord had brought Israel out of Egypt and had preserved them and blessed them throughout their journey to the Promised Land. God encouraged and warned Israel always to remember what he had done for them from Sinai onward ([Exod 3:15](#); [Deut 5:15](#); [Pss 77:11](#); [111:4](#); see also [Pss 78](#), [136](#)). • Balak . . . Balaam: (see [Num 22–24](#)). • Acacia Grove, located on the east of the Jordan River, was Israel's base camp before entering the Promised Land (see [Num 25:1](#); [Josh 2:1](#); [3:1](#)). The trip from there to Gilgal (west of the Jordan River) bears witness to God's covenant faithfulness. God's saving acts brought the Israelites into the Promised Land.

Micah 6:6–7

Israel's case was hopeless, but they queried the Lord as to how they could placate or please him. The proffered items are listed in a crescendo of significance, from calves to rams and olive oil to firstborn children. None of this was sufficient or acceptable to God, who judges the heart ([1 Sam 15:22](#); [16:7](#); [Jer 17:9](#)).

Micah 6:8

Good means what is right in God's eyes; God is the source of all goodness ([Gen 1](#); [Exod 33:19](#); [34:6–7](#); [Deut 12:28](#)). • what is right (Hebrew mishpat, often translated “justice”): God's order in the world requires treatment of others in fair, non-manipulative, non-oppressive ways. • mercy (Hebrew khesed): This passionate, undeserved loyalty is the defining quality in God's holy character (see [Ps 136](#)). Those who know God will act in the same way toward others (see [Gen 21:22–24](#); [Josh 2:12–14](#); [Matt 5:43–48](#)). • walk humbly: Humility must characterize God's people. They must not live in a spirit of arrogance or special privilege. They must be humble and reverently fear God. Mishpat and khesed are incompatible with human arrogance. God desires us to be in an ongoing intimate relationship with him (a “walk”; cp. [Deut 28:9](#); [Josh 22:5](#)) that transforms the way we relate to other people.

Micah 6:9

Those who are wise fear the Lord; God's voice calls to everyone in Jerusalem to learn wisdom (cp. [Prov 1:7](#), [20](#), [28](#)). • The armies of destruction . . . sending them: Assyria would carry out the Lord's plan to destroy Samaria, while Babylon would be the instrument of destruction for Jerusalem ([Mic 4:10](#)).

Micah 6:9–16

People in Jerusalem were here invited to learn the lesson from Samaria: If you oppress others in order to have an abundance for yourself ([6:10–12](#)), you will never have enough however much you get ([6:13–15](#)), and eventually you will lose even that ([6:16](#)). It is fitting for such people to become an object of scorn, not to receive honor and adulation ([6:16](#)).

Micah 6:10–12

The Lord had specific accusations against his people. They had become a community of deceit that was ripe for rejection and destruction. Falsely acquired wealth, unethical business practices, threats, and violence characterized this supposed people of God (see [2 Kgs 6:25](#); [Hos 12:7–8](#); [Amos 8:5–6](#)). They could not change, because lying was

their way of life (cp. [Prov 6:16–19](#)). Israel was completely corrupt.

Micah 6:13–16

I will wound you! This phrase introduces all of the curses that God had promised to bring upon the disobedient and rebellious people of Israel (see [Deut 28:15–68](#)).

Micah 6:16

These kings began perhaps the most rebellious dynasty to reign in northern Israel (885–841 BC; [1 Kgs 16:23–2 Kgs 10:17](#)), and Elijah condemned them to annihilation ([2 Kgs 10:17](#)). No northern kings of Israel followed the laws of Moses (cp. [Mic 1:5–6](#)). Omri and his son Ahab were the epitome of evil kings (e.g., [1 Kgs 18:4](#); [21:1–26](#)). Omri's dynasty was destroyed in 841 BC ([2 Kgs 9:14–10:17](#)), and the people of Israel who followed their evil example would similarly be destroyed.

Micah 7:1

the fruit picker after the harvest: After the second crop of figs and fruit in August–September, no further yield was produced for several months (cp. [Isa 16:9](#); [Jer 48:32](#)). No one could be found to satisfy Micah's hunger for righteousness ([Mic 7:2–6](#)).

Micah 7:1–20

Hopeless deception and corruption permeated God's people ([7:1–6](#)); God's mercy, however, would triumph and Israel would be restored ([7:11–13](#)). God's mercy, compassion, and unfailing love would prevail ([7:14–20](#)). Micah mourned his people's condition and looked to the Lord for help ([7:7–10](#)).

Micah 7:2

This complaint is frequent in the prophets (see [Isa 59:16](#); [Jer 5:1](#); [Ezek 22:30](#)). • In the ancient Near East, people fished and hunted by setting traps and using nets (cp. [Ps 10:9](#); [Prov 1:17](#); [Isa 51:20](#)). • their own brothers: All fellow Israelites were regarded as brothers.

Micah 7:2–6

The people of Israel were without law, justice, or righteousness. Everyone took advantage of others for self-aggrandizement; they had created a society in which all forms of oppression were the norm.

Micah 7:3

That is, they had perfected the skills for doing evil.
• Officials and judges alike demand bribes: Rulers and judges were forbidden to twist justice ([Exod 18:19–22](#); [Deut 16:18–20](#)). Israel's judicial system was completely corrupt.

Micah 7:4

your judgment day is coming: The people of Israel would soon be conquered by the Assyrians, the people of Judah would soon face destruction at the hands of the Babylonians, and all the people of the earth will soon face God in judgment.

Micah 7:5–6

Don't trust anyone: Bitterness, corruption, and treachery had poisoned the community of the Lord's people (cp. [Matt 10:34–36](#); [Luke 12:52–53](#)).

Micah 7:7–10

In the midst of despair, Micah prays with a psalm of hope and confidence in the Lord (cp. [Hab 2:4](#); [3:16–18](#)).

Micah 7:8

Though I sit in darkness: The prophet confidently trusts in God to be his light (cp. [Ps 27:1](#)) even in deep difficulty, knowing that his enemies would not overcome him (cp. [Ps 23:4–5](#)). God's Spirit gave him the power and confidence to perform his prophetic task ([Mic 3:8](#)).

Micah 7:9

I have sinned: The prophet and other godly people recognize their own failure and culpability, yet trust in the Lord for redemption. • The Lord's righteousness brings salvation and rescue for his people.

Micah 7:10

where is the Lord? This taunt rebuked God and those who trusted him. God had promised always to be with his people and their leaders ([Gen 46:3–4](#); [Exod 3:12](#)). God was dishonored by these taunts, and he would act to clear his name (cp. [Ezek 20:9](#); [36:19–26](#)).

Micah 7:11–12

That day includes (1) 538 BC, when Israel began to return from exile in Babylon (see [Ezra 1–2](#)); and (2) the final restoration of God's people (see [Amos 9:11–15](#)). As the nations flow to a renewed Israel, God's purposes through Abraham will be fulfilled ([Gen 12:3](#)).

Micah 7:13

Before their restoration, Israel must be disciplined ([Deut 4:29](#); [28:37](#), [48](#), [63](#); [30:1–6](#)). • empty and desolate: The people's intransigent wickedness brought on God's judgments.

Micah 7:14

• With a shepherd's staff, an ancient Near Eastern shepherd could defend his sheep from wild beasts. Likewise, the prophet prayed that God would protect his people from hostile Gentile nations (cp. [Exod 4:1–5](#)). • special possession: Cp. [Exod 19:5](#); [Deut 7:6](#); [14:2](#); [26:18](#); [Mal 3:17](#); [1 Pet 2:9](#). • Bashan and Gilead, east of the Jordan River, were part of the Lord's earliest gifts to the Israelite tribes of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh ([Josh 13:15–31](#)). Assyria annexed these territories and took these tribes away in the 700s BC. Israel's ownership would be restored and expanded.

Micah 7:14–20

The Lord promised to completely renew Israel, his special possession (see [Exod 19:5](#); [Mal 3:17](#)). Judgment would not mean the destruction of hope, but a cleansing so that true hope could prevail. The restoration would be God's work alone as he restored the remnant of his special people and removed their guilt by his love, compassion, and faithfulness (see [Exod 32:12–14](#)).

Micah 7:15

Israel's enslavement to sin and to other nations called for mighty miracles such as those that brought Israel out of Egypt.

Micah 7:16

The promise that all the nations would be blessed by the descendants of Abraham ([Gen 12:3](#)) would be fulfilled in this restoration of God's special people.

Micah 7:17

Like snakes, the nations had struck at the heel of Israel (cp. [Gen 3:14–15](#)). The prophets regularly depicted foreign nations as poisonous, deceitful serpents ([Isa 14:29](#); [Jer 8:17](#); [Ezek 29:1–3](#)). Now these nations would be humbled (cp. [Ps 72:9](#)). Crawling and "eating dust" were metaphors for defeat and humiliation.

Micah 7:18–20

These verses provide a fine brief summary of Old Testament theology. God is unique; there is no one and nothing else like him. Because of his unfailing love (Hebrew *khesed*), he does not destroy his people whom he judges but instead restores them (see [Exod 36:6–7](#)). His faithfulness means that he can be trusted to do good regardless of the cost to himself (see [Ps 89:1–2](#)). • Where is another God like you: This question probably plays off of Micah's name ("Who is like the Lord?"). God's character is unequalled among the gods of the nations. His actions and words spring from his character ([Exod 34:6–7](#)). God pardons, shows compassion, triumphs over his peoples' sins, and

seals those sins away. The Lord's unfailing love moved him to choose Israel from the beginning ([Deut 7:8](#)), consistent with his covenant faithfulness to Israel's ancestors ([Deut 7:20](#); [9:1-10:22](#)). By his unfailing love, God continues to offer hope to those who trust in him.